CAT 2026: 50-Day Plan to Target 99.5+ Percentile

Prepared 5 October 2026 | With daily tick tracker | Starting level: near-beginner in VARC, DILR and QA | Full-time study, about 9 hours on a normal day

Assumptions and dates

- I assumed all three sections start at zero, with a B.Tech CS background, and about 9 hours on a normal day. If you can do 10-12 hours, put the extra into DILR sets and RC practice rather than adding topics.
- **CAT 2026** is on Sunday, 29 November, in three slots (8:30 AM, 12:30 PM, 4:30 PM). It is expected to have 68 questions, 40 minutes per section, +3 for a correct answer, -1 for a wrong MCQ and no negative marking for TITA. The form-correction window is 5-6 October; the admit card is expected around 4-5 November.
- **Festival dates:** Dussehra 20 Oct, Karva Chauth 29 Oct, Dhanteras 6 Nov, Diwali 8 Nov, Bhai Dooj 11 Nov.
- Day 1 is 5 Oct and Day 50 is 23 Nov. That leaves **5 buffer days (24-28 Nov)**, not 4, and the exam is on Day 56.

1. What the papers show

These proportions are approximate, based on the papers I know best (strongest from 2015 onwards). Treat them as patterns, not exact counts.

Format history

- **2005-2014:** the format was different (two sections, mostly adaptive-style online), so only the topic patterns are useful.
- **2015-2019:** about 100 questions, 3 sections of 60 minutes each, and generally easier.
- **2020 onwards:** 120 minutes, 40 minutes per section with no switching, about 66-68 questions. Papers got more reading-heavy, TITA grew, and DILR became the section that decides ranks.
- **Recent split:** about 24 VARC, 22 DILR and 22 QA (204 marks). Confirm this in the 2026 bulletin.

QA (about 22 questions)

Area	Share	Verdict
Arithmetic	~30%	**Must-Do:** percentages, profit & loss, TSD, time & work, ratio/mixtures, SI/CI, averages
Algebra	~25-30%	**Must-Do:** quadratics, inequalities/modulus, functions, logs, progressions, surds/indices
Geometry & mensuration	~20%	**Must-Do:** triangles, circles. **Should-Do:** coordinate, polygons, 3D
Number system	~10-12%	**Must-Do:** remainders, factors, bases, HCF/LCM
Modern math	~10%	**Should-Do:** PnC, basic probability, sets. **Skip:** Bayes-style probability, derangements

Skip advanced trigonometry, matrices and the binomial theorem. They are rare or absent.

DILR (about 22 questions, 4-5 sets)

- **Must-Do:** arrangements (linear, circular, matrix), selection/grouping with conditions, tournaments/scheduling, tables and caselets.
- **Should-Do:** games/puzzles, networks/routes, Venn-based sets.
- **Skip as a first pick in the exam:** very calculation-heavy multi-graph sets.

VARC (about 24 questions)

- **Must-Do:** RCs, roughly 16-18 questions from 4 passages. Para jumbles (TITA) are also Must-Do, but skip the long ones in the exam.
- **Should-Do:** para summary and odd-one-out.
- **Skip:** grammar rules and vocabulary lists. They have not been tested in years.

Best marks per hour for a beginner: QA arithmetic + algebra + number system first, then daily RC practice. DILR has the highest variance. It needs volume (aim for about 80 sets solved) and the habit of picking the right sets.

2. The 50-day plan and tracker

Daily rhythm: QA in the morning, DILR midday, VARC late afternoon, then 30-45 minutes of mistake log at night. The VARC hours include 30-40 minutes of editorial or long-form reading. Take a walk every 90 minutes. The plan has about 9 light days (4-5 hours, all three sections still touched).

Abbreviations: PJ = para jumble, PS = para summary, OOO = odd-one-out, PYQ = previous-year question, TSD = time-speed-distance, PnC = permutations and combinations. **Log** = nightly mistake-log update. The admit card is expected around 4-5 November, so check your slot then.

How to use the tracker

- Every task has a **tick box**. The boxes are real PDF form fields, so you can tap or click them in Adobe Acrobat, Apple Preview, Files on iPhone and most other PDF apps, or print the pages and tick with a pen.
- **Day %** = tasks ticked / tasks that day x 100. Each day shows its task count, so 3 of 4 is 75%. Write it in the Day % box.
- **Week %** = tasks ticked in the week / tasks that week. The whole plan has 178 tasks (the exam day has none).
- On mock days, write your **raw marks and percentile** in the Raw and %ile boxes. Ticks measure completion, not learning: a day can be 100% ticked and still have weak accuracy, so the mock scores are the real signal.
- Light days count the same as full days. If you tick every task on a light day, that day is 100%.

Overall progress ☐ % of the 178 tasks ticked. Streak of 100% days: ☐

Blue row = full mock day | Green row = light / rest day

D	Date	VARC	DILR	QA	Log	Hrs	Day %
Phase 1: Foundations (Days 1-20)							
Week 1 (Mon 5 Oct - Sun 11 Oct)					**Wk %**		☐ %
1	Mon 5 Oct	☐ RC method + 2 untimed RCs, start daily reading	☐ Linear arrangements (3 sets)	☐ Percentages, profit/loss, discount	☐	9	☐ % 4 tasks
2	Tue 6 Oct	☐ 3 RCs, log why each wrong option is wrong	☐ Circular + multi-attribute arrangements	☐ Ratio, proportion, averages, alligation	☐	9	☐ % 4 tasks
3	Wed 7 Oct	☐ 3 RCs + 3 PJ	☐ Selection / grouping sets	☐ TSD (trains, boats, races)	☐	9	☐ % 4 tasks
4	Thu 8 Oct	☐ 3 RCs (20 min cap)	☐ Tables + caselets	☐ Time & work, pipes	☐	9	☐ % 4 tasks
5	Fri 9 Oct	☐ 3 RCs + 3 PJ	☐ Bar / line / pie DI sets	☐ SI/CI, mixtures + 25 arithmetic PYQs	☐	9	☐ % 4 tasks
6	Sat 10 Oct	☐ 3 RCs + PS intro	☐ 2 LR + 1 DI (20 min each)	☐ Number system I: divisibility, factors, remainders	☐	9	☐ % 4 tasks
7	Sun 11 Oct	☐ **Mock 1 (diagnostic, ignore the score)** Raw ☐ %ile ☐ ☐ 3h analysis + mistake log update ☐ Catch up on weak topics				8	☐ % 3 tasks
Week 2 (Mon 12 Oct - Sun 18 Oct)					**Wk %**		☐ %
8	Mon 12 Oct	☐ 3 RCs, mixed genres	☐ Tournaments / scheduling	☐ Number system II: HCF/LCM, bases, unit digits	☐	9	☐ % 4 tasks
9	Tue 13 Oct	☐ 3 RCs + 5 OOO	☐ Games / puzzle PYQ sets	☐ Algebra I: linear / quadratic	☐	9	☐ % 4 tasks
10	Wed 14 Oct	☐ 3 RCs + 5 PJ	☐ Networks / routes, binary logic	☐ Algebra II: inequalities, modulus	☐	9	☐ % 4 tasks
11	Thu 15 Oct	☐ 1 RC + reading	☐ Redo 1 set from Mock 1	☐ Redo 20 mistake-log Qs		4-5	☐ % 3 tasks
12	Fri 16 Oct	☐ 3 RCs timed	☐ Multi-graph / calculation-heavy DI	☐ Algebra III: functions, logs, surds, indices	☐	9	☐ % 4 tasks
13	Sat 17 Oct	☐ 3 RCs + 5 PJ + 5 PS, VARC sectional #1	☐ 3 PYQ sets, timed	☐ Algebra IV: progressions + 25 algebra PYQs	☐	9	☐ % 4 tasks
14	Sun 18 Oct	☐ **Mock 2** Raw ☐ %ile ☐ ☐ 3h analysis + mistake log update				8	☐ % 2 tasks

D	Date	VARC	DILR	QA	Log	Hrs	Day %
Week 3 (Mon 19 Oct - Sun 25 Oct)					**Wk %**		☐ %
15	Mon 19 Oct	☐ 2 RCs + 10 PS/OOO	☐ PYQ sets (2019-20)	☐ Geometry I: triangles, similarity, centres	☐	9	☐ % 4 tasks
16	Tue 20 Oct (Dussehra)	☐ 2 RCs	☐ 1 set	☐ Geometry formula sheet + 10 Qs		4-5	☐ % 3 tasks
17	Wed 21 Oct	☐ 3 RCs	☐ 3 PYQ sets	☐ Geometry II: circles, polygons	☐	9	☐ % 4 tasks
18	Thu 22 Oct	☐ 3 RCs + 5 PJ	☐ 3 sets in weakest type	☐ Coordinate geometry + mensuration	☐	9	☐ % 4 tasks
19	Fri 23 Oct	☐ 3 RCs (philosophy / science)	☐ DILR sectional #1 + analysis	☐ PnC I: counting, arrangements, selections	☐	9	☐ % 4 tasks
20	Sat 24 Oct	☐ 3 RCs + 5 PS	☐ 2 PYQ sets	☐ PnC II, probability, sets; QA sectional #1	☐	9	☐ % 4 tasks
Phase 2: PYQs, sectionals and mocks (Days 21-40)							
21	Sun 25 Oct	☐ **Mock 3** Raw ☐ %ile ☐ ☐ 3h analysis + mistake log update Target: percentile 65-80, raw marks 35-50				8	☐ % 2 tasks
Week 4 (Mon 26 Oct - Sun 1 Nov)					**Wk %**		☐ %
22	Mon 26 Oct	☐ RC speed: 4 RCs in 32 min	☐ 3 PYQ sets (20 min each)	☐ 30 arithmetic PYQs + fix Mock 3 gaps	☐	9	☐ % 4 tasks
23	Tue 27 Oct	☐ 3 RCs + 5 PJ timed	☐ 3 LR-heavy sets	☐ 30 algebra PYQs	☐	9	☐ % 4 tasks
24	Wed 28 Oct	☐ **Mock 4** Raw ☐ %ile ☐ ☐ 3h analysis + mistake log update				8	☐ % 2 tasks
25	Thu 29 Oct (Karva Chauth)	☐ 2 RCs	☐ Redo 1 set from Mock 4	☐ 20 mistake-log Qs		4-5	☐ % 3 tasks
26	Fri 30 Oct	☐ RCs + 10 PS	☐ 3 sets, weakest type	☐ 30 geometry / mensuration PYQs	☐	9	☐ % 4 tasks
27	Sat 31 Oct	☐ **Mock 5** Raw ☐ %ile ☐ ☐ 3h analysis + mistake log update				8	☐ % 2 tasks
28	Sun 1 Nov	☐ 2 RCs + 10 PJ/OOO	☐ DILR sectional #2	☐ QA sectional #2 + 30 number system / PnC PYQs	☐	9	☐ % 4 tasks
Week 5 (Mon 2 Nov - Sun 8 Nov)					**Wk %**		☐ %
29	Mon 2 Nov	☐ RC speed: 4 RCs in 30 min	☐ 3 PYQ sets (2022-23)	☐ 30 mixed timed PYQs	☐	9	☐ % 4 tasks
30	Tue 3 Nov	☐ **Mock 6** Raw ☐ %ile ☐ ☐ 3h analysis + mistake log update				8	☐ % 2 tasks
31	Wed 4 Nov	☐ 3 RCs + PS/OOO	☐ Weakest-type drill (3 sets)	☐ Weak topics from mistake log	☐	9	☐ % 4 tasks
32	Thu 5 Nov	☐ **Mock 7 (at your real slot time if the admit card is out)** Raw ☐ %ile ☐ ☐ 3h analysis + mistake log update Target: percentile 85-92, raw marks 60-75				8	☐ % 2 tasks
33	Fri 6 Nov (Dhanteras)	☐ 2 RCs	☐ 1 set	☐ 15 mistake-log Qs		4-5	☐ % 3 tasks
34	Sat 7 Nov	☐ 3 RCs	☐ 2 sets	☐ 30 mixed QA, timed	☐	7	☐ % 4 tasks
35	Sun 8 Nov (Diwali)	☐ 1 RC ☐ Read your mistake log (30 min). Rest for real.				2-3	☐ % 2 tasks
Week 6 (Mon 9 Nov - Sun 15 Nov)					**Wk %**		☐ %

D	Date	VARC	DILR	QA	Log	Hrs	Day %
36	Mon 9 Nov	☐ **Mock 8** ☐ 3h analysis + mistake log update		Raw ____ %ile ____		8	____ % 2 tasks
37	Tue 10 Nov	☐ 3 RCs + PS/OOO	☐ 3 sets	☐ 30 PYQs on weak topics	☐	9	____ % 4 tasks
38	Wed 11 Nov (Bhai Dooj)	☐ 2 RCs	☐ 1 set	☐ 15 mistake-log Qs		4-5	____ % 3 tasks
39	Thu 12 Nov	☐ **Mock 9** ☐ 3h analysis + mistake log update Target: percentile 93-95, raw marks 75-85		Raw ____ %ile ____		8	____ % 2 tasks
40	Fri 13 Nov	☐ RC + 10 PJ	☐ Re-solve every failed set	☐ Re-solve repeat-offender QA topics, 1-page formula sheet	☐	9	____ % 4 tasks
Phase 3: Mock-heavy (Days 41-50)							
41	Sat 14 Nov	☐ **Mock 10 (a past CAT paper)** ☐ 3h analysis + mistake log update		Raw ____ %ile ____		8	____ % 2 tasks
42	Sun 15 Nov	☐ VARC sectional + analysis	☐ DILR sectional + analysis	☐ Repair top-5 weak QA topics	☐	9	____ % 4 tasks
Week 7 (Mon 16 Nov - Sun 22 Nov)					**Wk %**		____ %
43	Mon 16 Nov	☐ **Mock 11** ☐ 3h analysis + mistake log update		Raw ____ %ile ____		8	____ % 2 tasks
44	Tue 17 Nov	☐ 3 RCs + 10 PJ/OOO	☐ Set-selection drill: scan 5 sets in 5 min, solve the best 2	☐ QA sectional	☐	9	____ % 4 tasks
45	Wed 18 Nov	☐ **Mock 12** ☐ 3h analysis + mistake log update Target: percentile 96-97, raw marks 85-95		Raw ____ %ile ____		8	____ % 2 tasks
46	Thu 19 Nov	☐ VARC sectional	☐ DILR sectional	☐ QA speed drill (30 TITA-style Qs)	☐	9	____ % 4 tasks
47	Fri 20 Nov	☐ **Mock 13** ☐ 3h analysis + mistake log update		Raw ____ %ile ____		8	____ % 2 tasks
48	Sat 21 Nov	☐ RC speed + weak question types	☐ 3 PYQ sets	☐ Redo QA mistake log	☐	9	____ % 4 tasks
49	Sun 22 Nov	☐ **Mock 14** ☐ 3h analysis + mistake log update Target: percentile 97-99, raw marks 95-105		Raw ____ %ile ____		8	____ % 2 tasks
Week 8 (Mon 23 Nov - Sun 29 Nov)					**Wk %**		____ %
50	Mon 23 Nov	☐ Review top-40 mistakes	☐ 2 DILR sets	☐ 25 mixed QA + formula sheet		7	____ % 3 tasks
Buffer days (no new topics). Exam is on Day 56.							
51	Tue 24 Nov	☐ **Mock 15 (at your real slot time)** ☐ 2h analysis + mistake log update Target: percentile 97-99, raw marks 95-105		Raw ____ %ile ____		6-7	____ % 2 tasks
52	Wed 25 Nov	☐ 2 RCs + 5 PJ	☐ 2 sets	☐ 20 weak-topic Qs	☐	6	____ % 4 tasks
53	Thu 26 Nov	☐ **Mock 16 (no new topics today)** ☐ 1.5-2h analysis + mistake log update Target: percentile 97-99, raw marks 95-105		Raw ____ %ile ____		6	____ % 2 tasks
54	Fri 27 Nov	☐ 2 RCs	☐ 1 set	☐ 15 easy QA + formula sheet		4	____ % 3 tasks
55	Sat 28 Nov	☐ Check admit card, ID and the route to the centre ☐ Sleep early				0-1	____ % 2 tasks
56	Sun 29 Nov	**CAT 2026 exam day. Good luck.**				-	

3. Mock strategy

How many? You cannot fit 50. This plan gives **16 full mocks plus 12-15 sectionals**, which is roughly 25 tests' worth of exam practice. A mock without analysis is wasted, so cut mocks before you cut analysis.

When to start: a diagnostic on Day 7, then regularly from Day 21. Take mocks at your actual slot time once you know it. Use past CAT slot papers (2021-2025) for some of the Phase 3 mocks.

The 3-hour analysis

- 40 min on attempt quality: what you attempted, what you should have skipped, and where the time went.
- 40 min on VARC: re-read each wrong RC and note why the right option wins.
- 50 min on DILR: re-solve every unsolved set untimed. This is where most learning happens.
- 40 min on QA: redo each wrong question and classify the error.
- 10 min to update the mistake log.

Mistake log columns: Question, section, topic, error type (concept, calculation, time, selection, silly), correct approach, redo date. Redo every entry after 3 days and again after 10.

Score targets (platform percentiles are rough guides)

By	Mock percentile	Raw marks (of 204)
Day 21	65-80	35-50
Day 32	85-92	60-75
Day 39	93-95	75-85
Day 45	96-97	85-95
Final 3 mocks	97-99	95-105

For 99.5+, expect roughly 95-105 raw marks, depending on slot normalisation. A path to about 100 is VARC 16-18 attempted at ~85% accuracy (~40 marks), DILR 11-12 attempted at ~80% (~27), and QA 14-15 attempted at ~80% (~31).

4. Videos: short or long?

- **Phase 1:** long videos for QA concepts, at 1.25-1.5x speed, one topic at a time. Do questions on that topic the same day. Keep videos under 40% of QA time.
- **After Phase 1:** short videos only to fix a specific doubt or learn a shortcut.
- **VARC and DILR:** no concept binges. Spend one or two sessions on strategy videos, then practise.
- **PYQs:** these are your main material. Use them topic-wise for QA after each concept. Use PYQ sets for DILR from Day 8, and PYQ RCs daily from Day 1. Treat CAT 2017-2025 slot papers as full mocks later.
- **One source per section.** Do not hop between channels. Pick one paid mock series from a major platform alongside the free past papers.

5. Do's and Don'ts

Do

- Do RCs every day from Day 1, even when you feel behind.
- Time everything from Day 10 onwards.
- Practise skipping: leaving a bad question or set is a skill.
- Keep the 30-45 minute nightly mistake-log session, even on light days.
- Protect sleep, especially in the last 10 days.

Don't

- Do not read grammar or vocabulary books.
- Do not start new topics after about Day 40.
- Do not chase every shortcut trick.
- Do not compare your mock percentile to others' in the first three weeks.
- Do not take a mock and skip the analysis.
- Do not change strategy in the last 3 days.

6. Exam-day strategy

- **VARC (40 min):** skim all 4 passages for 1-2 minutes, then start with the easiest. Spend about 8 minutes per RC and do the VA questions (PJ, PS, OOO) in about 10 minutes. Aim for 16-18 attempts and skip dense passages.
- **DILR (40 min):** spend the first 4-5 minutes scanning all sets and pick the 2 easiest. Solve them fully (about 15 minutes each), then try a third. If you are stuck for more than 5-6 minutes with no progress, switch. Aim for 10-12 questions.

- **QA (40 min):** do a first pass over all 22 questions in about 20 minutes, taking the easy and TITA ones. Do a second pass on the medium ones and leave 4-5 hard ones. Aim for 14-16 attempts.

You cannot carry time across sections, so use each 40 minutes fully.

7. If your mocks plateau

- **Stuck below ~85 percentile:** concept gaps, so go back to topic-wise PYQs.
- **High attempts, low accuracy:** you are rushing or guessing, so slow down and cut the weakest 20% of attempts.
- **Low attempts, high accuracy:** you are too cautious, so run timed sets with a hard 2-minute limit per question.
- **DILR is stuck:** it is usually set selection, not skill. Run the 5-sets-in-5-minutes drill daily.
- **VARC is stuck:** classify wrong RC answers as inference, tone or detail errors and drill that type.
- **No change after 3 mocks:** stop taking mocks for 2 days and do only error repair.

8. Weekly checkpoints

Checkpoint	You should have	If behind
Day 7	Diagnostic done, arithmetic and number system basics covered	Drop Should-Do topics
Day 14	Algebra covered, ~40 DILR sets done, 40+ RCs done	Cut geometry depth, keep the basics
Day 21	Mock 3 at 65+ percentile, all QA topics seen once	Compress PYQ blocks, not mocks
Day 28	Mock 5 at 80+, mistake log shows repeating patterns	Fix repeat offenders before any new practice
Day 35	Mock 7 at 88+, DILR attempts 2-3 sets reliably	Do extra set-selection drills
Day 42	Mocks consistently 93+	Re-run the plateau diagnosis (Section 7)
Day 49	Last 3 mocks within 3 percentile points	Stop adding anything new

If you slip by a day or two, take it from Should-Do topics and light days. Do not take it from mock analysis.

9. Is 99.5+ realistic?

It is a **long shot**. This is my judgement, not a measured statistic. Starting from near zero in all three sections with about 45 effective study days, a **95-98 percentile** is the realistic zone if you follow the plan, 99+ is possible if QA and DILR click, and 99.5+ needs most things to go right. A CS background should help with QA and DILR, while VARC from scratch will be the slowest to move. The most common route to 99.5+ is QA at 95+, DILR at 90+, and steady RC accuracy.